

Arthritis Treatment — Your Complete Guide to Managing Joint Pain

Explore every treatment option for arthritis, from NHS pathways and exercise to medication, physiotherapy, surgery, and complementary therapies. A complete map of what works.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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Living with arthritis means living with questions. *What will help? Where do I start? Am I doing enough?*

We understand. More than 10 million people in the UK live with arthritis — you are not alone. And while there is currently no cure, there is a great deal you can do to manage your symptoms and live well.

This guide walks you through every treatment option available on the NHS and beyond. Think of it as your map. You don't need to take every path; just the ones that are right for you.

What Treatment Options Are Available for Arthritis?

Arthritis treatment is not a single thing. It is a combination of approaches that work together. The National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) — the body that advises the NHS on best practice — recommends a stepped approach, starting with the safest, most proven options first.

The main categories are:

- Exercise and movement (NICE's first-line treatment)
- Weight management (if needed)

- Physiotherapy and occupational therapy
- Pain-relieving medications
- Disease-modifying drugs (for inflammatory types like rheumatoid arthritis)
- Surgery (when other options are no longer enough)
- Complementary and lifestyle approaches

Most people benefit from a mix of several of these.

NHS Treatment Pathway for Arthritis



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When you first visit your GP with joint pain, here is what the typical NHS pathway looks like:

- GP assessment — Your doctor will ask about your symptoms, examine your joints, and may arrange blood tests or X-rays.
- Diagnosis — You may be diagnosed with osteoarthritis (OA), rheumatoid arthritis (RA), or another form.
- First-line treatment — You will be offered advice on exercise, weight management, and pain relief. You may be referred to a physiotherapist.
- Ongoing management — If symptoms continue, your GP may prescribe stronger medication or refer you to a specialist (rheumatologist or orthopaedic surgeon).
- Surgery — In some cases, joint replacement surgery is considered when other treatments have not provided enough relief.

You have the right to be involved in every decision. The NHS calls this "shared decision-making."

Exercise and Movement as Treatment (NICE First-Line)

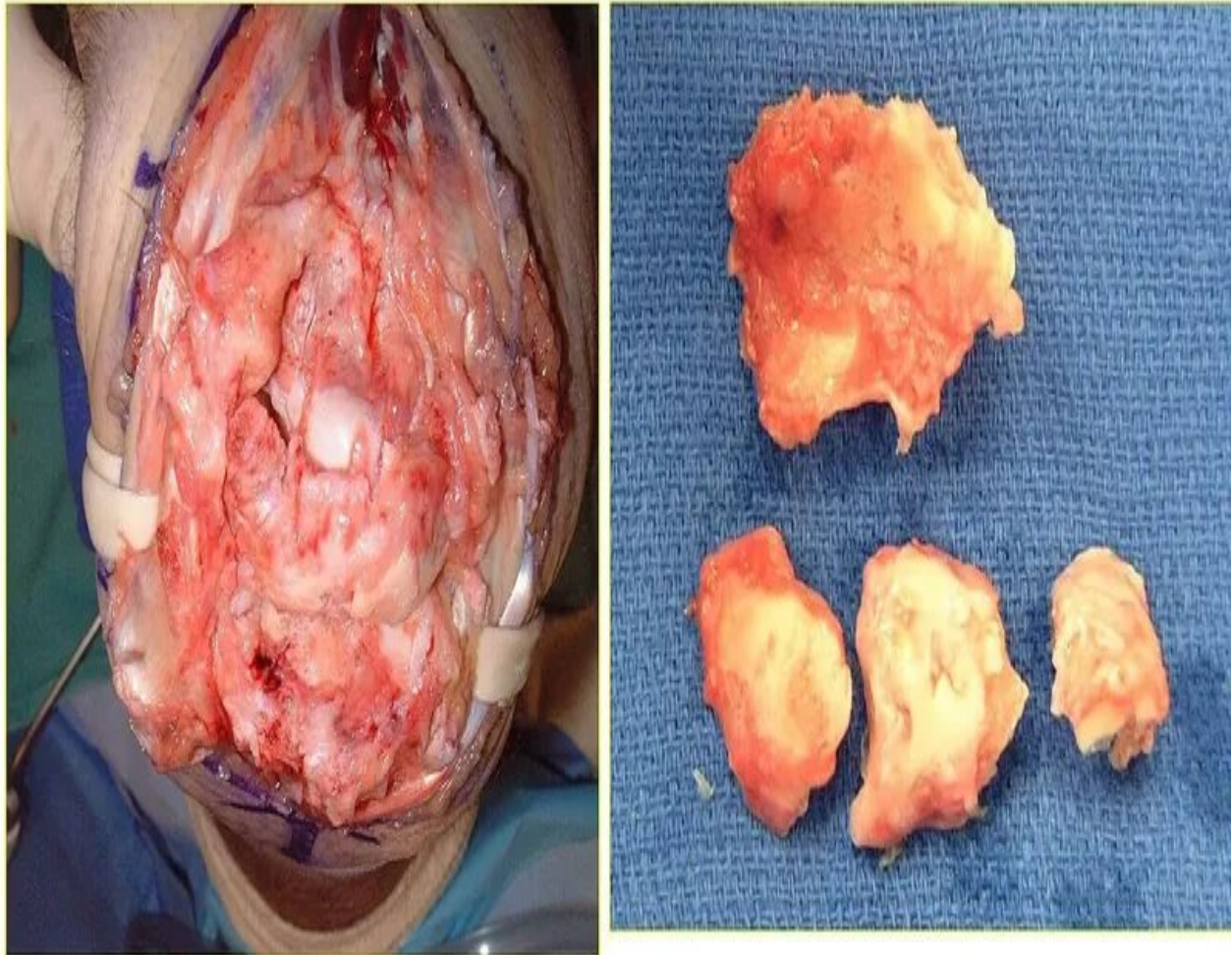
It may feel counter-intuitive to move a painful joint, but exercise is the single most effective treatment for arthritis. NICE guidelines are clear: **exercise should be the first thing offered to everyone with osteoarthritis** — before medication.

Here is why:

- It strengthens the muscles that support your joints
- It reduces stiffness and improves range of motion
- It helps maintain a healthy weight, reducing load on weight-bearing joints
- It releases natural pain-relieving chemicals called endorphins

What kind of exercise? Anything that gets you moving gently — walking, swimming, cycling, yoga, tai chi, or specific physio exercises. The key is to start small and build slowly. Even five minutes a day is a win.

Medications for Arthritis Pain and Inflammation



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Medication can help you stay active and comfortable. What you need depends on your diagnosis and the severity of your symptoms.

For Pain Relief

- Paracetamol — Often tried first. Helps with mild-to-moderate pain, though it does not reduce inflammation.
- NSAIDs (ibuprofen or naproxen) — Reduce both pain and inflammation. Available as tablets or gels.
- Opioids (codeine-based) — Sometimes used for short periods of severe pain. Carry a risk of dependence and are used cautiously.

For Inflammatory Arthritis

- DMARDs (methotrexate, sulfasalazine) — Treat the underlying disease process in RA, not just symptoms.
 - Biologics — Newer targeted treatments for RA that has not responded to standard DMARDs.
 - Corticosteroids — Powerful anti-inflammatories taken as tablets or injected directly into a joint.
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Physiotherapy and Occupational Therapy

A physiotherapist is a movement expert. They can assess your movement and strength, design a personalised exercise programme, teach you how to protect your joints, and offer hands-on treatment and pain relief advice. You can access NHS physiotherapy through your GP or by self-referring directly in many areas.

An occupational therapist (OT) helps you do the things that matter to you — work, hobbies, daily tasks. They might suggest joint protection techniques, gadgets and tools to make life easier, or changes to your home or workplace.

Surgery for Arthritis — When Is It Needed?



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Surgery is not a first choice. It is considered when you have severe persistent pain that limits your daily life, other treatments have not helped enough, and your joint is significantly damaged. The most common operations are total hip replacement, total knee replacement, and less commonly shoulder or ankle replacement. Joint replacement surgery has excellent outcomes — the vast majority experience significant pain relief and better mobility.

Complementary and Lifestyle Treatments

Many people find additional relief from acupuncture (some evidence for short-term pain relief), massage therapy, heat and cold therapy, mindfulness and relaxation, and dietary changes like a Mediterranean-style diet. Always speak to your GP before starting any complementary therapy.

Creating Your Personal Treatment Plan

- Start with movement — What gentle activity can you do today?
 - Talk to your GP — Be honest about your pain. Bring a list of questions.
 - Explore physiotherapy — Ask for a referral or self-refer.
 - Review your diet and weight — Small changes add up.
 - Build your toolkit — Heat packs, supportive shoes, a TENS machine? Find what works.
 - Stay informed — Read the other guides on this site. Knowledge is power.
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Q&A

Question: What Treatment Options Are Available for Arthritis?

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